

Foundation Crack Homeowner Panic — Action Checklist

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MEASURE AND DOCUMENT THE CRACK

- ☐ **Measure and Document the Crack, Photo with Ruler:** Take a timestamped photo of the crack with a ruler pressed firmly against it to establish a baseline measurement that proves whether the crack is growing over time and gives contractors a clear reference point for any repairs.
- ☐ **Measure and Document the Crack, Identify Crack Type:** Determine whether the crack is vertical, horizontal, stair-step, or diagonal because each pattern signals different underlying causes, and horizontal or stair-step cracks indicate more serious structural movement that requires professional evaluation.
- ☐ **Measure and Document the Crack, Measure the Width:** Use a ruler to measure the crack width in inches because cracks under 1/8 inch are typically cosmetic, cracks between 1/8 and 1/4 inch warrant close monitoring, and anything over 1/4 inch requires a structural engineer evaluation.
- ☐ **Measure and Document the Crack, Check for Displacement:** Look to see if one side of the crack sits visibly higher or lower than the other because displacement indicates differential settlement and absolutely requires a structural engineer's assessment before any repair work begins.

GET THE RIGHT PROFESSIONAL HELP

- ☐ **Get the Right Professional Help, Call Engineer First:** Contact a structural engineer before calling any contractor because engineers provide objective diagnoses while contractors have a financial incentive to recommend expensive work, and an engineer who tells you the crack is cosmetic saves you from unnecessary repairs.
 - ☐ **Get the Right Professional Help, Skip Home Inspectors:** Do not rely on a general home inspector for structural diagnosis because their license covers broad home systems rather than specialized structural engineering, meaning they can only flag concerns without providing the certified assessment lenders and buyers require.
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- **Get the Right Professional Help, Get Three Bids:** Obtain minimum three contractor bids if your structural engineer confirms repairs are needed because having the engineer's scope documented creates fair competition among contractors who would otherwise pitch different levels of work at wildly different prices.
- **Get the Right Professional Help, Reject Pressure Tactics:** Reject any contractor who claims you need immediate repair work without having reviewed engineering data because legitimate professionals understand that structural issues require proper assessment before any repair commitment, regardless of urgency claims.

MONITOR AND TAKE NEXT STEPS

- **Monitor and Take Next Steps, Store Photos Monthly:** Create a dedicated folder on your phone for foundation documentation and photograph the crack monthly with a ruler to track whether it changes in width or length, which provides evidence of progression that engineers and contractors need to determine appropriate action.
- **Monitor and Take Next Steps, Handle Water Separately:** Address any water coming through the crack by calling a waterproofing contractor separately because water management requires exterior drainage correction and sump pump installation that differs entirely from structural crack repair work.
- **Monitor and Take Next Steps, Know Evaluation Triggers:** Recognize that horizontal cracks, cracks over 1/4 inch wide, visibly growing cracks, and any visible displacement all require immediate structural engineer evaluation because these patterns indicate foundation movement that worsens without professional assessment and stamped documentation.
- **Monitor and Take Next Steps, Keep Engineer Report:** Request and retain the structural engineer's stamped written report because this document is what mortgage lenders, home insurance companies, and future buyers will require to verify the foundation condition and approve any sale or refinance transaction.

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